



BIOGRAPHY

HARRIET TUBMAN

Born into slavery c.1820 on a Maryland plantation, Harriet Tubman dedicated her life to freeing enslaved people as a “conductor” on the Underground Railroad—a secret network of routes whereby slaves escaped to free states. Tubman herself escaped slavery in 1849, using the railroad to flee to Philadelphia. From 1851 to 1857, she made two trips a year back to the South to help her family and many others escape. Tubman died of pneumonia in 1913.

suggested that black women did not feel pain, needed no assistance in childbirth, and did not suffer when separated from their children.

Children born of enslaved women were legally slaveholders’ property, so female slaves—known as “increasers” for their ability to reproduce—were seen as an investment. Slaves were encouraged to have families, but not allowed to legally marry, and families could be separated by sale at any time without warning. It was common for slave owners to have children with their slaves, who did not possess the legal, cultural, or physical power to resist their owner’s advances. Hypersexualized stereotypes of black women also made them more vulnerable to sexual violence. The abolitionist speaker and reformer Harriet Jacobs, who escaped from slavery and gave an account of her experiences in *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl* (1861), wrote that sexual harassment and abuse was widespread, and began for her when she was only 14 years old.

Resistance and abolitionism

Although enslaved women had very little control over their lives, they still fought their slavery. Refusing to work, or working slowly, were common methods of resistance. Some women broke the law and ran for freedom. Oney “Ona” Maria Judge, the enslaved maid of First Lady Martha Washington, evaded capture for over 30 years after her escape from the presidential house in 1796. Others rebelled on a larger scale; former slave Luiza Mahin reportedly made her home the headquarters of the Malê slave revolt of 1835, the biggest slave rebellion in Brazil. In August 1791, Cécile Fatiman, a Haitian voodoo practitioner, performed a religious ceremony at a slave meeting that helped to incite the Haitian Revolution, a successful anti-slavery revolt against French colonial rule.

From the late 17th century onward, the Enlightenment had placed a strong cultural emphasis on human rights, and philosophers argued that slavery

60%
of field laborers in
the British colonies
in 1838 were
enslaved women



was incompatible with a progressive, liberal society. The political battle to end slavery began in the late 1700s with abolitionist societies such as the French *Société des Amis des Noirs* and the English Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade,

founded in 1787. More countries banned slavery in the decades that followed the American Revolution (see pp. 130–133), but